



WACZIARG (L) AND
NATH AT THE
NEEMRANA HOTEL

FRANCIS
WACZIARG, 66

AMAN
NATH, 57

HERITAGE HOTELIERS
CO-CHAIRMAN, NEEMRANA GROUP
INITIAL INVESTMENT IN 1986 Rs 10 lakh
TURNOVER IN 2008 Rs 25 crore

SUCCESS MANTRA

Don't waste time when it comes to turning your dreams into action

biggest OBSTACLE

Needing 45 clearances from the Rajasthan government for a hotel

key to INNOVATION

Every property is unique, so reinventing is the way to go about it

HOLDING FORT

It was in the late 1970s in Rajasthan that Aman Nath and Francis Wacziarg saw the splendid remains of a fort, standing tall, atop a hill. Looking at the fascinating ruins, Nath thought, "What a waste. After all the energy and funds, masons and materials, love and planning that goes into a building, it just crumbles." It was this thought, the desire to bring the Neemrana Fort-Palace back to life, that became the start of a journey that has, over 20 years later, translated into 14 heritage properties painstakingly restored to their former glory.

The beginning, like all entrepreneurial ventures, was a challenge, though it didn't deter Nath and Wacziarg, co-chairmen of the Neemrana Group. The thought of giving up never crossed their mind. Not even when, Wacziarg remembers, they had to get 45 permissions to open a hotel in Rajasthan. Acquiring the fort was not a problem. The raja was willing to sell it. It's just that there had been no takers for 40 years. No one

wanted ruins. It seemed a liability. Not for this duo. The idea too, says Nath, was not considered novel at that time. But he adds, "In order to be an entrepreneur, it is important to understand that you don't walk along the dotted line. Of course, there is constant challenge, like from the government, which teaches the Indian entrepreneur to be persevering."

Nath and Wacziarg acquired the fort-palace in 1986 and took a year to clear the rubble and five more years to restore it before opening its doors to people. "The raja of Neemrana, Raja Rajinder Singh, came for the opening and said he had never thought he would see life in his ancestral fort," Wacziarg remembers. Now, 22 years later, what used to be three acres at nine levels has become six acres built at 11 levels.

"I think when people say, 'Boy, you have become a maharaja, you have so many palaces,' they miss the point completely. It's not about possession. If that which you touch and don't improve, that which you inherit